

This week in polling: Forecasters favor Democrats in Senate

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Don't read much into primaries' polling errors

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Updating the US Governance Tracker

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Lower tariff rates risk sharper deficit increase

This week in polling: Forecasters favor Democrats in Senate. While Eurasia Group maintains its view that the GOP is likely to hold its Senate majority (55% odds), the release of Nate Silver's Senate forecast has swung prediction markets away from Republicans. Silver, the godfather of quantitative election forecasting, places 56% odds on Democrats winning the chamber, slightly higher than any other major forecaster. Markets take Silver's forecast seriously; Republicans' odds of retaining the Senate fell on Kalshi by three points, from 54% to 51%, in the hour following the release.

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The most important element of the forecast is the likely-voter adjustment to the generic congressional ballot. That shifts the national environment by another 1.5 points toward Democrats, giving them an 8-point margin overall and handing them the bare edge in a number of close races. Most of the race-specific forecast follows from this topline adjustment.

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It's also notable that, Michigan excepted, Silver's projections of the final margin aren't far off the recent polling average. This is a model feature driven mostly by an empirical finding that voters tend to shift less over the course of the campaign than they used to, and that—at the national level, at least—the polling picture becomes settled earlier on. Potential state-specific moves are a threat to that outlook, but if Silver's assumption is correct, the midterm campaign could be mostly sound and fury, signifying nothing.

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Polling of individual races this week favored Democrats. In North Carolina, Democrat Roy Cooper held seven- and 11-point leads in two polls, confirming that this is Democrats' strongest pickup opportunity

this year. In Texas, Democrat James Talarico continues to hold a low-single-digit lead against Republican Ken Paxton, though an Emerson poll out giving Paxton a one-point lead is Republicans' best showing there in weeks; beyond Maine and North Carolina, Texas is probably Democrats' likeliest pickup. There hasn't been any polling of the Michigan race since the primary last week.

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We remain of the view that Republicans are still the narrow favorites (see The Senate race is now nearly a coin flip , 5 August 2026). But our 55% odds in favor of Republicans reflect the fundamental tightness of the race; forecasting it is like deciding on which side of a knife's-edge ridgeline to fall. With so many races hanging in the balance, the major takeaway from the forecasting landscape so far is that the race is as close to a tossup as possible, and macro factors—such as the potential reopening of the Strait of Hormuz—will play a vital role.

Primary polling errors are not warning signs for the general. The Democratic primaries in Michigan, Wisconsin, and Minnesota have featured large polling errors in absolute terms, with polls whiffing by double digits on candidates' true level of support.

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It's tempting to read this as polls overstating progressive support, which did happen in Michigan. But in Wisconsin, polls weren't far off on the progressive candidate's absolute vote share; the real error was that polls didn't pick up on the consolidation of the moderate field. In Minnesota, meanwhile, polls showed the moderate candidate slightly leading, only for her to lose by nearly 20 points.

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These polling misses are large in absolute terms, but they're not out of the ordinary for primaries, which are notoriously tricky to poll. The average error in presidential primaries over the last 25 years has been around 9 points; in Senate and gubernatorial races, it's around 13 points. Moreover, a number of races in this cycle have been unusually volatile, with multicandidate fields and late dropouts and re-entries.

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Polling misses in the primary likely don't have major implications for the general election; these misses are likely to be primary-specific, driven largely by differential non-response in an electorate with relatively low turnout. And the recent midterm track record of Senate polling is positive: General-election Senate polling was reliable in both 2022 and 2018, which bodes well for their performance in another midterm year.

Updating the US Governance Tracker. Eurasia Group is updating its tracker of executive actions undertaken by the Trump administration; the tracker rates individual actions by the extent to which they erode formal checks on executive power (the x-axis) and informal norms on the use of executive power (the y-axis).

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Two actions in the last two months fall in the upper-right quadrant, which we call "revolutionary": President Trump's immunity deal with the IRS and the investigation into California Governor Gavin Newsom and his family. The Newsom investigation is similar to other entries in that quadrant, but unlike the prosecution of former FBI chief James Comey, has not resulted in formal charges, so we see it as somewhat less check-eroding.

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We place three new entries in the top left quadrant, which includes actions that are clearly contrary to norms, but don't have significant implications for formal checks. These include installing Bill Pulte as

director of national intelligence, contrary to statutory requirements on intelligence experience; Truth Social selling early access to posts via a new API; and the prosecution of alleged saboteurs of the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool.

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Political events under the 250th celebration, particularly the UFC fight at the White House, fall in the bottom left. They don't implicate formal checks, and the norm they erode—on not holding explicitly political or campaign-focused events at the White House—is already weak at best.

Lower tariff rates risk sharper deficit increase. The Congressional Budget Office's monthly update stated that tariff revenues this year are running about \$250 billion, annualized, below their February ten-year budget projection, released just before the Supreme Court struck down emergency-powers-based tariffs.

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CBO's estimate that tariffs will bring in around \$150 billion in revenue this year is right in line with our assumption in our baseline "tariff revenues undershoot" scenario of our US deficit projection, which sees deficits lingering in the mid-6% of GDP through 2029 (see "Deficits likely to linger in low-to-mid 6% of GDP in Export restrictions on refined products likely by end of May , 11 May 2026).

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Revenues will likely continue to undershoot the CBO's February estimate, even if they pick up slightly later in the year; though we expect that the forced-labor and overcapacity Section 301 investigations to result in effective tariff rates at or near trade-deal rates, every day that passes without the imposition of the overcapacity tariffs is one in which US tariff revenues will run below initial projections.

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Tariff refunds are exacerbating the deficit picture: Customs and Border Protection has reported that it has already refunded \$100 billion of the \$165 billion paid in IEEPA tariffs, with at least another \$30 billion awaiting processing. On its own, that will add about another 30 basis points to US deficits this year. If Congress passes a one-off supplemental later this year in the \$80bn-\$100bn range, mostly containing new defense funding, that would also increase deficits (see below).

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Across tariffs, refunds, and spending, then the US deficit prognosis looks negative. This won't play into the midterms this year, but it may be an more important issue in the lead-up to the 2028 election—especially with a group of retiring senators, led by Dick Durbin (D-IL) and Bill Cassidy (R-LA), pushing to make plans to ensure Social Security's long-term solvency.

Quote of the Day

"We're a blue-collar retirement state with about 42% of the people living on fixed income. Property taxes are unsustainable for a lot of folks." – Brent Bien, a Republican gubernatorial candidate in Wyoming, quoted in the Wall Street Journal on a ballot measure he has pushed that would allow property owners to increase the amount of home value exempt from property taxes. The ballot measure is just one instance in what is becoming a broader nationwide property-tax revolt, playing out in red and blue states alike as a result of the recent run-up in real-estate valuations. If voters and their elected officials succeed in reducing property-tax increases it will gradually starve local governments of a key revenue source, forcing them either to cut local service provision or find other ways of making up the revenue.

On the Radar

27 July – 28 August: House on recess

10 August – 14 September: Senate on recess

19 August: Section 338 tariffs on Canada go into effect

1 September: Massachusetts primaries

9-10 September: GOP midterms convention

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

30 September: Government funding runs out

3 November: National midterm elections

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